

# NEW WAVE SCIENCE FICTION

- OE\_ISF\_HS30054, Unit 04



## NEW WAVE SF (1964–1969)

- **Michael Moorcock** becomes editor of *New Worlds* magazine
- Greater experimentation with narrative style, structure, and themes
- Focus on internal experience rather than external adventure

## ● REDEFINITION OF SF

- ● Before New Wave, SF was largely dominated by **Hard SF** which had stories focused on scientific accuracy, technological advancements, space exploration, and alien encounters
- Earlier works (e. g. **Isaac Asimov** and **Arthur C. Clarke**) emphasized logical problem-solving, technological wonders, and physical universe, with characters often secondary to scientific ideas
- **New Wave Era: Mid-1960s to early 1980s**
- Key influences: Cold War anxieties, rise of counterculture, political upheaval, and rapid technological changes

## ● SHIFT TO SOCIAL, PSYCHOLOGICAL, & PHILOSOPHICAL FOCUS

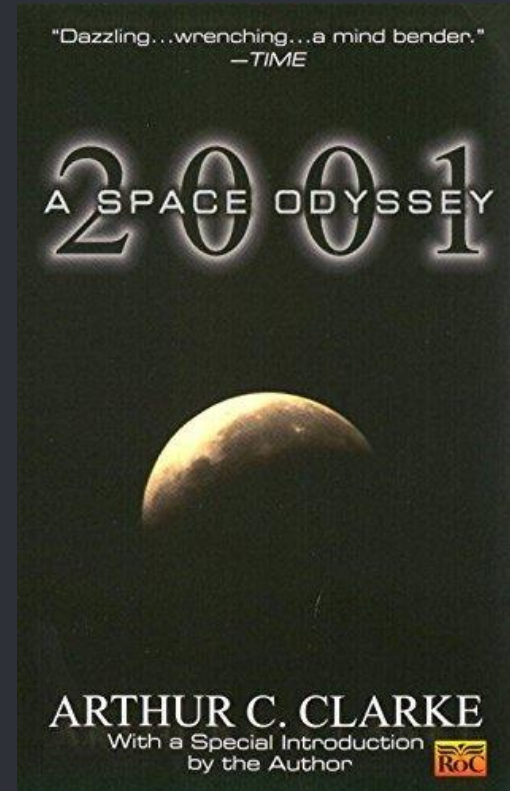
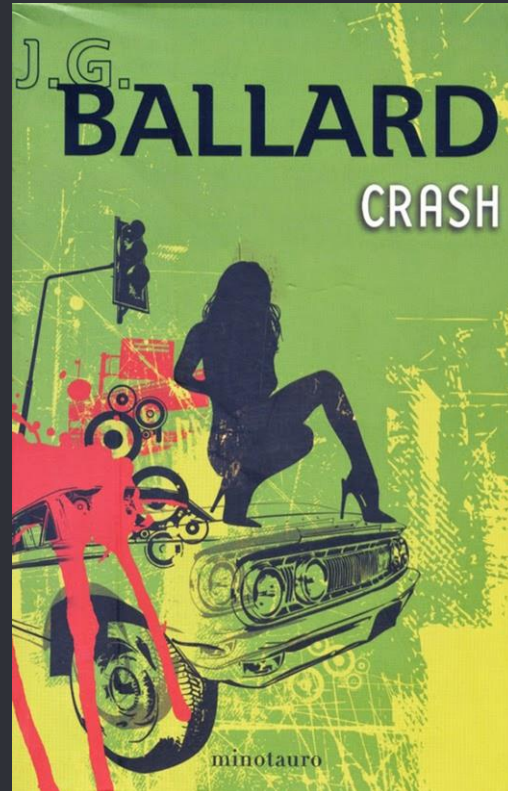
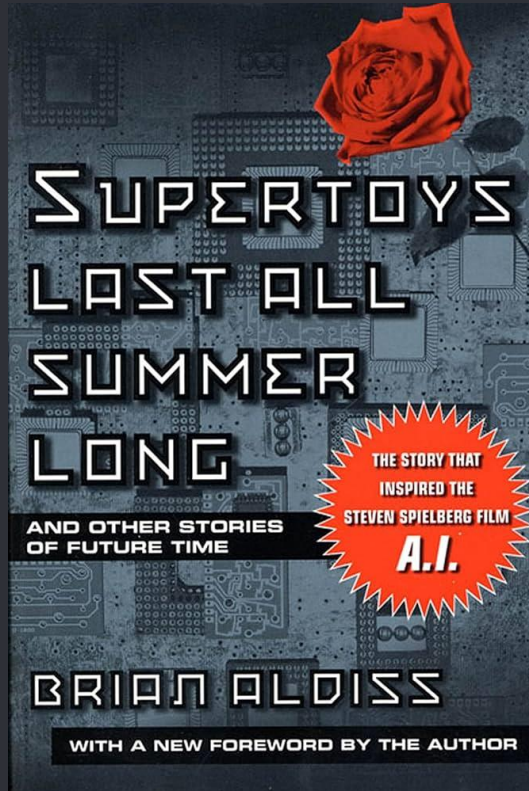
New Wave SF shifted from technical and adventure-based approach

- ✓ New Wave Explored **Social Issues**: Gender, race, sexuality, political structures, and social hierarchies became central themes e. g. *The Left Hand of Darkness* (1969) by **Ursula K. Le Guin** challenges binary gender norms through androgynous society
- ✓ **Psychological Depth**: Greater focus on inner consciousness, memory, perception, and mental states e. g. *A Scanner Darkly* (1977) by **Philip K. Dick** explores drug addiction and fragmentation of identity
- ✓ **Philosophical Questions**: What does it mean to be human? Can machines have consciousness? What is reality? E. g. *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968) by **Philip K. Dick** questions empathy, consciousness, and artificial life

## ● HUMAN vs. MACHINE & EMERGENCE OF AI

- **Philip K. Dick** , *Ubik* (1969): Reality and human identity destabilized by technology
- **Brian Aldiss**, *Supertoys Last All Summer Long* (1969): Emotional struggles of artificial beings
- **J. G. Ballard**, *Crash* (1973): Human obsession with technology and mechanization of desire
- **Harlan Ellison**, *I Have No Mouth, and I Must Scream* (1967): AI as malevolent force, controlling humanity
- **Arthur C. Clarke**, *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968): HAL 9000 as one of first true AI depictions
- **Samuel R. Delany**, *Nova* (1968): AI as tool for exploration and existential reflection

- BOOK COVERS



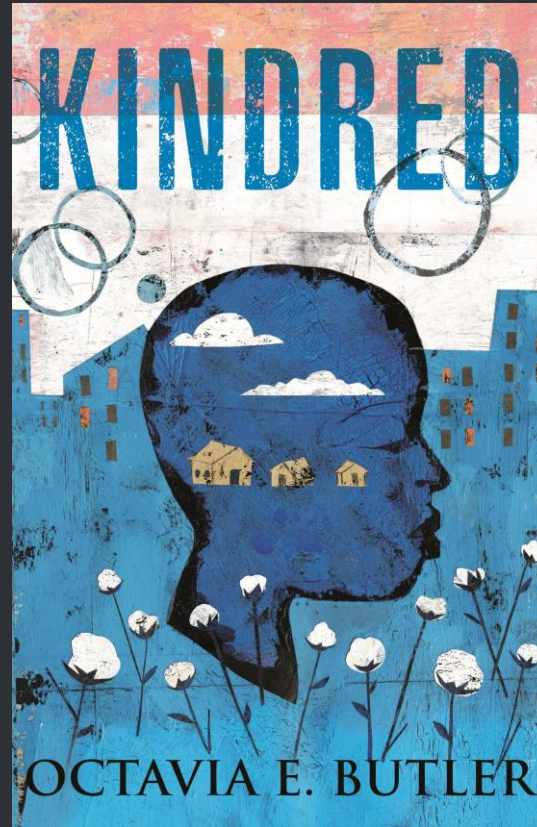
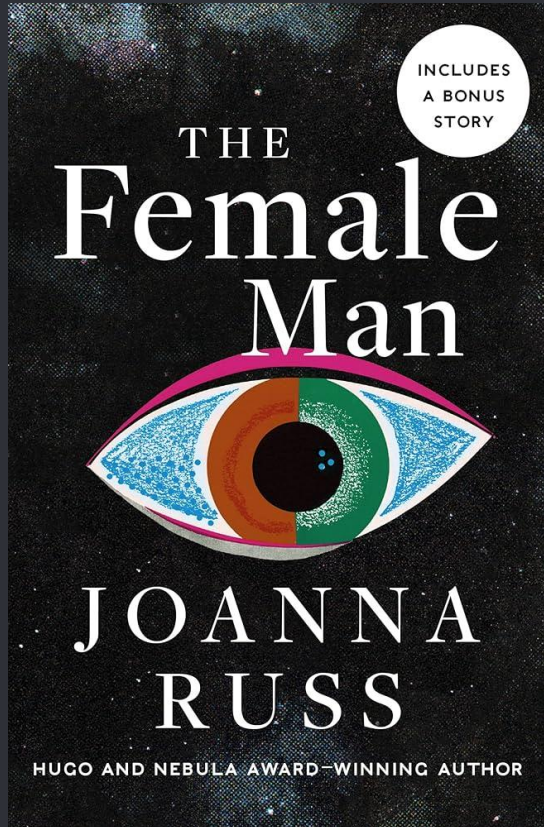
## ● CONSCIOUSNESS & POST-HUMAN CONDITION

- **John Brunner, *Stand on Zanzibar*** (1968): Corporate control and human identity shaped by technology
- **James Tiptree Jr., *The Girl Who Was Plugged In*** (1973): Commodification of identity and bodily autonomy through technology
- **Philip K. Dick, *A Scanner Darkly*** (1977): Fragmentation of consciousness due to drug use and surveillance
- **John Brunner, *The Shockwave Rider*** (1975): Predictive AI and control of information
- **John Varley, *The Ophiuchi Hotline*** (1977): Cloning and technological rebirth
- **Vonda N. McIntyre, *Dreamsnake*** (1978): Genetic engineering and human adaptability

## ● GENDER & IDENTITY & FEMINIST SF

- **Ursula K. Le Guin**, *The Left Hand of Darkness* (1969): Androgynous society challenges binary gender norms
- **Joanna Russ**, *The Female Man* (1975): Feminist critique of patriarchal norms through parallel universes
- **Samuel R. Delany**, *Trouble on Triton* (1976): Exploration of gender fluidity and social identity
- **Octavia E. Butler**, *Kindred* (1979): Intersection of race, gender, and time travel
- **James Tiptree Jr.**, *Houston, Houston, Do You Read?* (1976): Male dominance and social collapse
- **Alice Sheldon** (Tiptree's real name), Gender identity as a personal and social construct

## BOOK COVERS



## ● EXPERIMENTATION WITH NARRATIVE & FORM

- • **Experimental storytelling:** Stream of consciousness, nonlinear narratives, unreliable narrators, and fragmented timelines
- **Internal conflict over external adventure:** Less focus on space battles, more on personal identity and moral dilemmas
- **Overlapping genre boundaries:** Combining SF with elements of fantasy, horror, and surrealism e. g. **J. G. Ballard**, *The Atrocity Exhibition* (1970), disorienting narrative and technological violence, and **Samuel R. Delany**, *Dhalgren* (1975), blurring line between reality and perception

## ● PHILOSOPHICAL & EXISTENTIAL QUESTIONS

- New Wave SF made SF more introspective and socially aware
- It opened the door for cyberpunk and feminist SF, influencing how contemporary science fiction explores identity, technology, and society
- New Wave SF turned science fiction from an 'Adolescent' genre about **outer space** into a 'Grown-up' genre about **inner space**, exploring human mind, social structures, and existential questions
- Early explorations of AI, gender, and human-machine interaction shaped modern science fiction, continuing its relevance in contemporary discussions on AI, gender, and identity



THANK YOU!